

COLD WATER: FLOAT FIRST, THEN DECIDE

Print it and tape it in the boat. The first minute plan, the float position, and the rescue rules.

Most people who die in cold water do not freeze. They drown in the first minute or two. The instant cold water hits your skin, your body takes one huge involuntary gasp, 2 to 3 liters of air, and starts hyperventilating. If your face is under when the gasp fires, you inhale the lake. Cold water is a stopwatch, not a thermometer.

THE THREE PHASES, IN ORDER

Breathing	Cold shock. The gasp, then breathing four or five times normal. Peaks in the first 30 seconds. You cannot hold your breath.
Limbs	Cold incapacitation, roughly the next 10 minutes. Hands go first, then arms and legs. Some lose their hands in three minutes, some in twelve.
Core	Hypothermia, core below 95 F. Even in ice water, around 30 minutes to become mildly hypothermic, often over an hour before the cold itself can kill you.

NUMBERS TO KNOW

50 to 59 F	10 to 15 C. Where cold shock is strongest. A lake in May, a river in October.
Under 70 F	Treat it as cold, per the National Center for Cold Water Safety.
25 times	How much faster water pulls heat away than air at the same temperature.
87 percent	Of 2024 boating drowning victims, where the Coast Guard knew, had no life jacket on. 556 died; about three in four drowned.



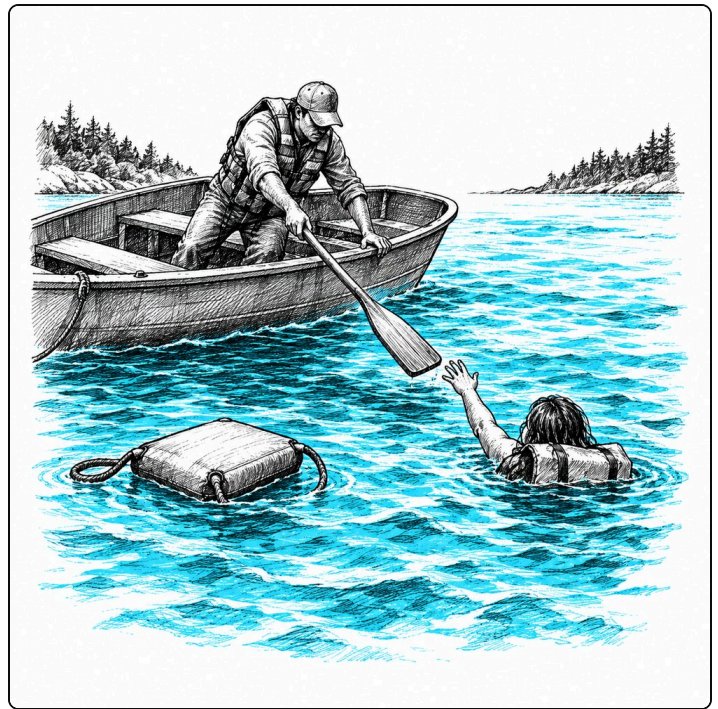
Float to live: lie back, ears under, arms and legs out, mouth in the air.

THE FIRST MINUTE PLAN

- 1 Fight the urge to fight.** Do not swim, thrash, or grab for anything yet.
- 2 Lie back.** Legs up, ears under, arms and legs out a little like a starfish. Skull gently to keep your face up.
- 3 Just breathe** for 60 to 90 seconds while the gasping runs its course.
- 4 Boat right there?** Get to it, hold on, and get as much of you out of the water as you can, even onto a capsized hull.
- 5 Shore a short swim?** Go now while your arms still work, steady not fast.
- 6 Nothing close?** Stop swimming. Knees up, arms hugged across your chest: the heat escape lessening posture.
- 7 Kick off boots** if they drag, but keep your clothes on.



Nothing close: knees up, arms across the chest, hold still.



Reach or throw. Do not go in after them.

THE 30 DOLLAR VEST

- ☐ **Wear it, do not stow it.** A jacket in a locker has a survival rate of zero.
- ☐ A plain foam vest that fits, around 30 dollars, holds you up through the gasp with no effort.
- ☐ Open water: the big orange offshore type rolls even an unconscious person face up.
- ☐ Inflatable belt packs do nothing until you pull the cord, with hands that may be failing.

RESCUE RULES

- ☐ **Do not jump in after them.** That is how one drowning becomes two.
- ☐ Reach with an oar. Throw a line, a cushion, a cooler, anything that floats.
- ☐ Bring the boat to them. Go in only as the very last option, and only with a jacket on.
- ☐ Entering cold water on purpose? Wade in slowly and splash your face and neck first.
- ☐ Sudden cold immersion can stop a weak heart. Do not test yourself.

Watch the full video: youtube.com/@SketchySurvival101

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